



British prime minister Neville Chamberlain (right) visited Nazi Germany for the Munich Conference on September 28.

WALT DISNEY'S REWORKING OF THE FAIRY TALE OF SNOW WHITE

and the Seven Dwarfs marked the transition of animated movies from cartoon shorts aimed primarily at children to a major strand in film culture. Dismissed in advance as "Disney's Folly," *Snow White* was an immediate hit, briefly holding the record for the **highest grossing movie** of all time before being overtaken by *Gone with the Wind* (see 1939). The ability of Hollywood to manufacture universally appealing, mass-market films, along with the influence of American **big-band** "swing" dance music, was laying the foundations for a US-dominated, **international popular culture**.

All was not well with the **US economy**, however. A sharp **rise**



Animated feature

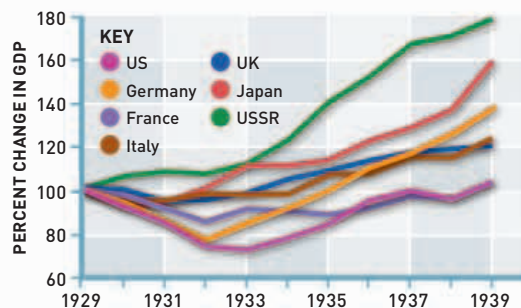
Walt Disney's *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs* was the first feature-length, animated movie to be released worldwide, in 1938.

in unemployment in 1938 drew attention to the fact that President Roosevelt's New Deal (see 1933) had failed to solve the economic problems of the US Depression.

By comparison, although pockets of high unemployment persisted in Britain, the **British**

economy was performing well in the late 1930s, with high levels of house building, burgeoning production of consumer goods—from cars to vacuum cleaners—nationwide electrification, and growth in high-tech industries such as aircraft manufacturing. A symbol of **Britain's technological success** was the performance of the streamlined A4 Pacific-class locomotive *Mallard*. On July 3 it reached 126 mph (203 kph), setting a **world speed record** for a steam engine that has never been surpassed.

The year's first major international crisis came in March, with the German **annexation of Austria**—the **Anschluss** ("unification"). Hitler had been applying mounting pressure on the government of



Economic growth

The Soviet Union achieved high economic growth in the 1930s. Japan and Germany also recovered well from the Depression.

Austrian Chancellor Kurt Schuschnigg (1897–1977) to back the Nazi movement inside Austria. When Schuschnigg attempted to hold a **referendum on Austrian independence**, Hitler forced his resignation and launched an **invasion**. German troops crossed the border unopposed; Hitler was greeted in Vienna by cheering crowds. The annexation was

accompanied by widespread attacks by Nazis on Austria's large Jewish population.

Although the unification of Germany and Austria was a major **breach of the Versailles Treaty** (see 1919), Britain and Germany made no attempt to intervene. Instead, British prime minister **Neville Chamberlain** embarked upon an active policy of



- January 1** Census of US unemployment declares at least 7.8 million out of work
- February 4** Animated movie *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs* released
- January 27** German war minister Werner von Blomberg forced to resign
- February 10** King Carol II of Romania dismisses parliament, establishes royal dictatorship
- February 14** British naval base at Singapore becomes operational
- February 20** British Foreign Secretary Anthony Eden resigns to join opponents of government foreign policy
- February 24** Toothbrush provides first commercial use of nylon
- March 3** Arabian American Oil Company discovers oil in Saudi Arabia
- March 12–13** In the Anschluss, Germany absorbs Austria into the Reich
- March 14** Prominent Soviet former leaders executed after show trials
- March 16–18** In Spanish Civil War, German and Italian bombing of Barcelona kills 670 people
- March 18** Mexico nationalizes foreign oil companies
- April 25** Anglo-Irish agreements include handing back of British-held Treaty Ports to Ireland
- May 13** Japanese launch major offensive against Chinese Nationalists, initiating **Battle of Wuhan**
- May 26** US House of Representatives' Un-American Activities Committee begins investigating communist influence
- May 28** Hitler tells German officers he intends to destroy Czechoslovakia by war
- June 12** Widespread attacks on Roma and Sinti people in Germany and Austria
- June 15** Hungarian Lázló Biro patents ballpoint pen
- June 25** Fair Labor Standards Act sets minimum wage and bans child labor in US